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Reading: Playbooks, SIEM tools, and SOAR tools

Previously, you learned that security teams encounter threats, risks, vulnerabilities, and incidents on a regular basis and that they follow playbooks to address security-related issues. In this reading, you will learn more about playbooks, including how they are used in security information and event management (SIEM) and security orchestration, automation, and response (SOAR).

Playbooks and SIEM tools

Playbooks are used by cybersecurity teams in the event of an incident. Playbooks help security teams respond to incidents by ensuring that a consistent list of actions are followed in a prescribed way, regardless of who is working on the case. Playbooks can be very detailed and may include flow charts and tables to clarify what actions to take and in which order. Playbooks are also used for recovery procedures in the event of a ransomware attack. Different types of security incidents have their own playbooks that detail who should take what action and when.

Playbooks are generally used alongside SIEM tools. If, for example, unusual user behavior is flagged by a SIEM tool, a playbook provides analysts with instructions about how to address the issue.

Playbooks and SOAR tools

Playbooks are also used with SOAR tools. SOAR tools are similar to SIEM tools in that they are used for threat monitoring. SOAR is a piece of software used to automate repetitive tasks generated by tools such as a SIEM or managed detection and response (MDR). For example, if a user attempts to log into their computer too many times with the wrong password, a SOAR would automatically block their account to stop a possible intrusion. Then, analysts would refer to a playbook to take steps to resolve the issue.

Key takeaways

What is most important to know is that playbooks, also sometimes referred to as runbooks, provide detailed actions for security teams to take in the event of an incident. Knowing exactly who needs to do what and when can help reduce the impact of an incident and reduce the risk of damage to an organization's critical assets.